



CHANDRA FOODS · RECIPE GUIDE

How to Make Pani Puri at Home in the UK

Recipe, ingredients and where to buy them

Pani puri is the one snack nobody eats politely. A crisp shell, a spoon of spiced potato, a dunk in ice-cold mint water, and the whole thing goes in at once. You do not need a street stall in Mumbai for that. With a ready-made **pani puri packet** and about 30 minutes of prep, you can make pani puri at home in the UK that tastes the way it should.

This guide gives you a full pani puri recipe with measurements, a shopping list split by where you will find each item, and fixes for the things that usually go wrong.

SERVES

4 people, around 40 puris

PREP TIME

30 minutes, plus 2 hours chilling for the pani

COOKING

Boiling potatoes only. No frying if you buy the shells

ALSO CALLED

Golgappa, phuchka, gupchup

What Is Pani Puri?

Pani puri is one of the best-loved **Indian snacks**, a chaat made of four parts that only meet at the last second: a hollow fried shell (the puri), a spiced potato and chickpea filling, a sweet chutney, and the pani, a chilled herb water that is sour, salty and hot all at once. The name is literal. Pani means water, puri is the shell.

The golgappa you get in Delhi and the north tends to have a sharper, spicier water and a plainer potato filling. Bengali phuchka uses a tangier tamarind water and mashed potato with black chickpeas. Gupchup is the name in Odisha and parts of central India. The Gujarati and Mumbai version, which is the one this recipe follows, adds sprouted moong or white chickpeas and often a sweet date-tamarind chutney. In Gujarati homes it usually shares the table with other **Gujarati snacks** such as **fafda**, **gathiya** and **chakri**.

Pani Puri Ingredients: Your UK Shopping List

The method is easy. The shopping is what trips people up, because no single supermarket shelf has everything. Here is how it splits.

From an Indian snack specialist

- **Pani puri shells (golgappa puri).** Making these from scratch means rolling semolina dough paper thin and frying it so each piece puffs into a hollow ball. Even experienced cooks lose a few flat ones per batch. Ready-made shells are what most households use, and Chandra Foods **pani puri shells** arrive already fried and crisp, so there is no hot oil involved.
- **Sev.** Fine nylon sev is the classic topping. Thikhi sev or ratlami sev works if you want more heat.
- **Boondi.** A handful floated in the pani is how many stalls serve it.

From the world foods aisle or a local Indian grocer

- Black salt (kala namak)
- Chaat masala
- Tamarind concentrate or block tamarind
- Jaggery, or dark brown sugar as a stand-in
- Cumin seeds

From any supermarket

- Fresh mint and coriander
- Green chillies, ginger, a lemon
- Potatoes, a tin of chickpeas, a red onion

Black salt is the one item not to skip. Its slightly sulphurous tang is what makes pani taste like pani, and table salt cannot copy it.

Pani Puri Water Recipe (Teekha Pani)

Make this first. It needs time in the fridge.

YOU WILL NEED

30g fresh mint leaves (a large handful, stalks removed)

30g fresh coriander, stalks included

2 to 3 green chillies

1 cm piece of ginger

2 tbsp tamarind concentrate

1½ tsp roasted cumin powder

1 tsp black salt

1 tsp chaat masala

Juice of half a lemon

1 litre cold water

METHOD

- 1 Blend the mint, coriander, chillies and ginger with 100ml of the water until completely smooth.
- 2 Strain the paste through a sieve into a large jug, pressing with a spoon to get all the liquid out.
- 3 Stir in the tamarind, cumin, black salt, chaat masala, lemon juice and the rest of the water.
- 4 Taste it. It should be slightly too strong on its own, because the shell and potato will mellow it.
- 5 Chill for at least 2 hours. Add ice and a handful of boondi just before serving.

Sweet pani (meetha pani)

Stir 3 tbsp tamarind concentrate and 3 tbsp grated jaggery into 500ml warm water until dissolved. Add a pinch each of roasted cumin and black salt, then chill. Put this out next to the green pani so children and anyone who avoids heat can still join in.

Pani Puri Filling

YOU WILL NEED

3 medium potatoes (about 400g), boiled and peeled

1 x 400g tin of chickpeas, drained, or 150g sprouted moong

1 small red onion, finely chopped (optional)

½ tsp chaat masala

½ tsp roasted cumin powder

A pinch of chilli powder and salt

2 tbsp chopped coriander

METHOD

Break the potato up with a fork so it stays chunky, then fold in everything else. Keep it at room temperature. Cold filling tastes dull.

How to Assemble and Eat Pani Puri

- 1 Tap the top of a shell with your thumb or the back of a teaspoon to make a hole about the size of a 10p coin.
- 2 Add a teaspoon of filling. The shell should be about half full.
- 3 Add a few drops of sweet chutney or meetha pani if you like.
- 4 Dunk the shell into the green pani, or spoon the pani in until it is nearly full.
- 5 Eat it in one bite, straight away. A filled puri goes soft in under a minute.

Hosting a Pani Puri Night

Pani puri works best as a help-yourself station. Put the shells, filling, sev and two jugs of pani in a row and let people build their own. Plan on 8 to 10 puris per adult if it is a starter, and 12 to 15 if it is the main event.

For a family table, the Family Pani Puri Combo saves working out quantities yourself.

Once the pani and potato are made, turning one dish into a chaat spread takes very little extra work, because the same base ingredients carry across:

- **Sev puri:** flat **chaat papdi** topped with potato, onion, chutney and plenty of sev
- **Papdi chaat:** **papdi**, potato, chickpeas, yoghurt and both chutneys
- **Dahi puri:** the same pani puri shells filled with potato and yoghurt instead of pani
- **Bhel puri:** a **bhel puri mix** tossed with onion, chutney and sev

Not everything has to be assembled. A bowl of masala papdi is an easy papdi snack to leave out for anyone who wants crunch without the build, and a few Indian savoury snacks on the side keep people going between rounds.

If you are feeding a bigger crowd, the Ultimate Chaat Party Combo covers the crunchy parts in one order. Finish with masala chai. It settles the heat better than anything cold.

How to Store Pani Puri Leftovers

- **Pani:** up to 3 days in a sealed bottle in the fridge. Stir before using, as the spices sink.
- **Filling:** up to 2 days in the fridge. Bring back to room temperature before serving.
- **Shells:** in an airtight tub at room temperature, away from steam and damp. Never refrigerate them.
- **Assembled puris:** do not keep. Only fill what will be eaten.

Pani Puri FAQs

Where can I buy pani puri shells in the UK?

Indian grocers stock them, and you can order them online from Chandra Foods, which has been making Indian snacks in the UK since 1985. Larger supermarkets sometimes carry kits in the world foods aisle, though the range is limited.

Is there a pani puri point or papdi chaat near me?

If you live near Wembley, Southall, Tooting or Leicester's Belgrave Road, you will find chaat houses serving pani puri, dahi puri and papdi chaat. Everywhere else, a search for a pani puri point, papdi chaat near me or dahi puri near me often comes back empty. That is the best reason to keep shells and papdi in the cupboard: you can buy pani puri shells online, and the rest is a 30-minute job at home.

Is golgappa the same as pani puri?

Yes. Golgappa, phuchka, gupchup and pani puri are regional names for the same snack. The shell is the same, and the water and filling change slightly from region to region.

How many pani puri per person?

Allow 8 to 10 per adult as a starter and 12 to 15 as a main. Children usually manage 5 or 6.

Can I make pani puri without tamarind?

You can use extra lemon juice with a pinch of sugar. It will be sharper and less rounded, since tamarind has a fruity sweetness lemon does not have.

What can I use instead of black salt?

Sea salt with a squeeze of lemon is the closest substitute, but the flavour will be noticeably different. If you plan to make pani puri more than once, a small bag of kala namak is worth buying and lasts for months.

Can I make the pani a day ahead?

Yes, and it is better that way. The flavours settle overnight. Add the ice and boondi only when you serve.

How do I keep pani puri shells crisp?

Keep them sealed until the moment you serve, and reseal any opened pack in an airtight container. If they soften, a few minutes in a low oven brings the crunch back.

Ready for pani puri night?

Order crisp, ready-made shells and Indian snacks online from Chandra Foods, made in the UK since 1985.